



Labyrinths



Tlon, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius

- How does the framing of the encyclopedia influence the story?
- In Tlon, languages do not have nouns -- they are based on impersonal verbs or monosyllabic adjectives. How does a language without “things” change how a person perceives reality? Can we actually think about a world without nouns?
- Tlon is a world governed by Berkelyan idealism - which is the belief that objects only exist because they are perceived. How does Borges use this philosophy in his representation of his world?
- The story concludes with the real world slowly being overwritten by the “fictional” history of Tlon. How does this reflect modern concerns about misinformation, echo chambers, and the social construction of truth?



The Garden of Forking Paths

- Why do you think Borges uses the “found document” technique? How does it aid in the way the story is told? How does it affect the story’s credibility?
- What is the significance of a maze made out of time rather than space?
- Ts’ui Pen believes in an infinite series of times that diverge and converge. How does this relate to multiverse theory? What does this imply about ideas of free will and destiny?
- Albert explains that in most instances of time, he and Yu Tsun are enemies, but in others they are friends. How does this realization affect the tone of their encounter at the end?



The Lottery in Babylon

- Would you participate in a lottery with non-monetary elements? If you were the company, what would you put at a prize or punishment that was “made” for you?
- If every event is determined by the Lottery, does free will exist in Babylon?
- Why do you think the Babylonians reject a lottery that only has “good” outcomes? Why is a purely positive lottery considered “imperfect”?
- At the end of the story, there are rumors that the Company has ceased to exist, or it never existed at all. How does this ambiguity change your interpretation of the story?



The Circular Ruins

- The magician suffers anxiety that his son will discover he is merely a projection. Why do you think the magician wants to spare his son from this realization?
 - How do you think the magician feels upon his own realization at the end of the story?
 - How do the elements of the story aid in the general theme of what Borges is trying to convey?
 - The *circular* ruins, the god of *fire*?
- 



The Library of Babel

- How does Borges play with the concepts of infinity in this story? Is the library truly infinite? In what ways is the library infinite? In what ways is it not?
- How does Borges play with the concepts of order and chaos throughout this story?
- If every single sentence you could ever speak, write, or think already exists in a book somewhere in the library, does “creativity” or “originality” actually exist?



Funes the Memorious

- Borges makes a comment during this story about how “to think is to forget a difference, to generalize, to abstract.” Do you think Funes is incapable of thought? If so, how does Funes’ inability to forget prevent him from true “thought.”
- Funes is able to remember every single detail of his life with absolute clarity. Compare this to the Understand story we read in Stories of Your Life.
- Funes has trouble with the word “dog” because it does not differentiate dogs seen from the front, vs dogs seen from the side, vs a dog seen on Tuesday, vs a dog seen today. What is Borges implying about generalization and categorization?



Death and the Compass

- This story can be read as a parody or a subversion of classic detective fiction. How does Borges challenge the idea that the universe is orderly, rational, and solvable by human intellect?



The Sect of the Phoenix

- Borges famously noted in an interview that the secret rite represents sex. How does viewing the “Secret” as a mundane, universal biological act change your interpretation of the story?



The Immortal

- This story proposes that death is what gives human actions and relationships their value. Do you agree with this?
- During the end of the story, the narrator confesses that he might be Homer, or he might be someone else who has absorbed the memories of others. How does memory function when it stretches towards infinity?



The House of Asterion

- How does shifting the point of view to the Minotaur change your perception of him from the original Greek myth?
 - At what point in the story did you realize who Astarion actually was?
 - How does Borges use the labyrinth to represent his ideas about the world?
- 
- 



The Zahir

- Borges struggled with failing health throughout his life, specifically his vision which was degraded from an early age and worsened until he was blind at 55. How do you see this reflected in his story?

The Writing of the God

- Calling back to *Story of Your Life*, individuals who could comprehend the alien script also learned to perceive time non-linearly. How does this story mirror the same conclusion?